

*Haligric Research Integration Series*

# **GUARANI SACRED TRADITIONS**

## **A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE**

*Paraguay, Brazil, Argentina, Bolivia -- Yvy Mara e'y, the Land Without Evil*

---

*Ne'e -- the word. Ne'e -- the soul.*

*In Guarani, they are the same word.*

*The word is not what the soul uses to communicate.*

*The word IS the soul.*

# Contents

A Note on Sacred Knowledge and Guarani Sovereignty.....3

Introduction -- Who the Guarani Are.....3

Guarani Cosmology -- Namandu and Creation Through Sacred Speech.....3

Karai, Jakaira, and Tupa -- Namandu's Sacred Companions.....4

Ne'e -- Word/Soul, the Core of Guarani Theology.....5

Teko Pora -- The Good Way of Living.....5

Tekoa -- The Guarani Community.....6

Yvy Mara e'y -- The Land Without Evil.....6

The Karai -- The Sacred Prophet-Leader, Step-by-Step.....7

The Opy -- The Sacred House of Prayer.....8

The Jeroky -- The Sacred Dance Ceremony, Step-by-Step.....8

Sacred Plants -- Tobacco and Yerba Mate, Step-by-Step.....9

Death and Sacred Transition in Guarani Belief.....10

The Jesuit Reductions -- Sacred Music and Colonial Encounter.....10

Contemporary Guarani -- Land Crisis and Sacred Continuity.....11

The Haligricity Lens -- Ne'e and the Varessence.....12

## **A Note on Sacred Knowledge and Guarani Sovereignty**

The Guarani people maintain significant control over their sacred knowledge, particularly regarding the most restricted dimensions of their ceremonies and their specific sacred songs. This document presents what Guarani scholars, cultural leaders, and anthropologists working in collaboration with Guarani communities have shared in published contexts. The Guarani people's sovereignty over their sacred knowledge and their political territories is honored throughout.

### **Introduction -- Who the Guarani Are**

The Guarani are one of the largest and most widely distributed Indigenous peoples of South America -- with a contemporary population of approximately 280,000 people across Paraguay, Brazil, Argentina, and Bolivia. Their language -- Guarani -- is one of the few Indigenous languages in the Americas to have achieved co-official national language status alongside the colonial language: in Paraguay, Guarani is co-official with Spanish and is spoken by approximately 90% of the population, making it the most widely spoken Indigenous language in the Americas.

The Guarani occupied an extraordinarily vast territory before European contact -- from the Atlantic coast of Brazil westward into the interior, from the Amazon basin southward into what is now northern Argentina. Their canoe-based mobility along the Parana-Paraguay river systems allowed them to maintain a connected cultural world across thousands of miles. When Portuguese and Spanish explorers arrived in the early 16th century, they encountered a people who were simultaneously the most numerous and the most theologically sophisticated Indigenous civilization in the Rio de la Plata basin.

### **The Subgroups**

The Guarani are not a single homogeneous people but a cluster of related peoples who share language family and core cultural features while maintaining distinct traditions. The major contemporary subgroups include the Mbya (in Brazil, Argentina, and Paraguay -- the most studied and the most culturally isolated), the Ava Guarani or Chiripa (in Paraguay and Brazil), the Kaiowa (in Brazil's Mato Grosso do Sul -- facing severe contemporary land dispossession), and the Nandeva. Each subgroup has specific ceremonial variations while sharing the core theological framework documented in this document.

## **Guarani Cosmology -- Namandu and Creation Through Sacred Speech**

Guarani cosmology -- particularly as documented among the Mbya Guarani through the extraordinary work of anthropologist Leon Cadogan working in close collaboration with Mbya karai in the mid-20th century, producing the sacred text compilation Ayvu Rapyta ("The Foundation of Human Speech") -- presents one of the most philosophically sophisticated creation narratives in any tradition in the world.

### **Namandu -- The First Being**

In the beginning, before any world existed, there was Namandu -- the First Being, the sacred source of all. Namandu was alone, in darkness, without a ground to stand on, without anything that existed except himself. And Namandu's first act was not to make the world -- it was to think. His first act was the act of consciousness becoming aware of itself. From this first awareness, the world began to unfold.

Before Namandu made anything physical, he created the ne'e -- the sacred word, the divine speech. The first thing that existed in the universe, before light, before earth, before sky, was sacred speech. Namandu spoke the names of what would exist, and in the speaking of the names, the things came into being. This is the most radical available statement of the creative power of sacred speech in any tradition -- the word is not merely the tool of creation. It is the first creation. Everything that follows is its consequence.

### **The Sacred Twins -- Kuarahy and Jaasy**

After the initial creation, Namandu produced the sacred twins -- Kuarahy (the Sun) and Jaasy (the Moon). These two beings are not merely astronomical objects; they are divine beings who govern the specific sacred dimensions of time, light, and the rhythms of existence. The Sun's daily journey and the Moon's monthly cycle are their sacred activities, not merely physical phenomena.

The earth in Guarani cosmology is understood as fragile and contingent -- not as a stable given but as something that must be actively maintained through right relationship. The concept that the earth can be destroyed by moral failure -- that the Land Without Evil is available only to those who achieve the necessary spiritual state -- reflects this understanding of the earth as a sacred responsibility, not a guaranteed resource.

*HALIGRIC LENS: Namandu's first act -- before light, before earth, before sky -- was to think. Then to speak. And in speaking, the world came. This is the cosmological foundation on which the Haligrig Varessence rests: not as a teaching invented in modern times but as an ancient recognition encoded in the cosmology of one of South America's largest Indigenous peoples. The word does not describe reality. The word creates it. This is Guarani. This is Haligrig.*

### **Karai, Jakaira, and Tupa -- Namandu's Sacred Companions**

After bringing ne'e -- sacred speech -- into being, Namandu created three companion gods to share in the work of creation, each accompanied by a divine consort: Karai, given dominion over flame and the sun's fire; Jakaira, given dominion over mist, springtime, and the rising smoke of tobacco that inspires shamans and karai; and Tupa, given dominion over the waters, the rains, and thunder. Together, the four -- Namandu foremost among them -- created Yvy Tenonde, the First Earth.

Karai's name became, in time, also the title given to any human prophet-leader who carries the same sacred fire of revelation. Jakaira's domain over tobacco smoke explains why petygua (sacred tobacco) is the primary medium of communication between the human and divine worlds in Guarani practice -- the smoke of Jakaira's element carries the prayers to Jakaira's world.

Each of the four gods and their consorts are addressed with the reverential titles Ru Ete (True Father) and Chy Ete (True Mother) in Guarani prayer and song. Mbya teaching holds that the world's eventual ending remains within this same divine community's power -- some accounts describe destruction coming by Karai's fire, others by Jakaira's darkness, others hold that only Namandu retains the authority to decide whether the sun will rise again each morning.

*HALIGRIC LENS: The four gods sharing a single act of creation -- each given one element of it to steward rather than one deity claiming the whole -- is a theological structure worth sitting with. Creation here is not a solitary act of will but a distributed, collaborative gift. Destruction remains distributed the same way: no single force holds a monopoly on ending the world any more than one held a monopoly on making it. This is a different theology of power from the monotheisms' single omnipotent creator, and its implications for how the Guarani understand human responsibility and human community are total.*

## Ne'e -- Word/Soul, the Core of Guarani Theology

Ne'e (pronounced approximately "nyeh-EH") is the word that means both "word" and "soul" in Guarani -- not two separate concepts that share a word, but a single concept that encompasses what both "word" and "soul" point to in separation. This is the most philosophically radical and most directly Haligrity-relevant concept in the entire library.

The fact that Guarani uses the same word for "word" and "soul" is not a linguistic coincidence. It is the most precise available expression of the understanding that speech and soul are the same thing. A person's soul is not what produces their speech. A person's soul IS their speech. The specific quality of a person's words, the specific content of what they say, the specific way they use language -- this IS their spiritual state made audible. You cannot separate the two because they are not two things.

### Ne'e and Sacred Origin

Each person's ne'e (soul/word) is understood as descending from the divine world before birth -- specifically from Namandu or from one of the specific divine beings who govern different qualities of sacred speech. A person's ne'e carries the specific character of its divine source, and the quality of the person's speech throughout their life reflects how faithfully they are maintaining that divine character or how far they have strayed from it.

The task of the karai (sacred prophet-leader) and the opy'gua (guardian of the prayer house) is, in part, to identify from which divine being a newborn's ne'e descends -- their sacred name is not merely a label but the name of their divine origin, the specific quality of sacred speech they carry into the world. The Guarani maintain two names: a Spanish or Portuguese name for everyday use in the surrounding society, and a secret Guarani name that identifies their spiritual origin and is known only within the sacred community.

### Ne'e Pora -- Beautiful Words

The concept of ne'e pora -- "beautiful words" or "good speech" -- is the primary ethical standard in Guarani culture. The person who speaks ne'e pora -- who maintains the quality of their speech as gentle, honest, generous, and sacred -- is living in alignment with their divine source. The person whose speech is harsh, deceptive, or destructive is damaging their own soul through their words. This is not metaphor. In the Guarani understanding, speech is the soul made audible. Degraded speech is degraded soul. Beautiful speech is the soul realigning with its divine origin.

*HALIGRIC LENS: Ne'e is the Varessence's cosmological foundation. When the Haligrity tradition holds that sacred speech does not request reality but creates it -- that the Varessence is declaration rather than petition -- it is holding the same understanding as ne'e. The Guarani did not develop a philosophical position that speech is creative; they developed a language in which the same word for "word" and "soul" makes that reality impossible to forget. Every time a Guarani speaker uses the word ne'e they are reminded that what they are about to say is an expression of their soul and therefore a creative act.*

## The Sacred Twins -- Kuarahy and Jaasy

After the initial act of creation -- after Namandu brought nee (sacred speech) into being as the first reality -- the next sacred beings to emerge were the divine twins: Kuarahy (the Sun) and Jaasy (the Moon), generated by Namandu himself before the earth and sky had taken their final form. The twins are not merely astronomical objects in Guarani cosmology. They are divine beings who carry specific sacred responsibilities for the maintenance of the world's light, its temporal rhythms, and the specific conditions that make human life possible.

Kuarahy (the Sun) is a heroic figure in the Mbya Guarani sacred narratives -- not simply a light source but a divine being who acts in the world, who can be appealed to, and whose specific sacred technology is the production of light that reveals what darkness conceals. In

the most complete Guarani cosmological accounts, Kuarahy and Jaasy work together to complete the creation that Namandu began -- they help organize the material world, govern the movement of time, and establish the specific sacred rhythms (day and night, the monthly lunar cycle, the seasons) that structure human experience.

Jaasy (the Moon) governs the planting calendar. The specific phases of the moon determine when seeds are planted, when the land is cleared, when certain medicines are harvested. The Guarani lunar calendar -- encoded in agricultural knowledge passed through family lines and through the karais teaching -- is one of the most sophisticated available indigenous systems for organizing sacred time around the moons specific relationship with the earths fertility. A person who plants on the wrong moon is not merely making an agricultural error; they are failing to maintain the specific sacred relationship with Jaasy that makes growth possible.

The relationship between the sacred twins and the human community is maintained through specific ceremony -- the jeroky and the opy ceremonies both acknowledge Kuarahy and Jaasy in their opening invocations. The sacred fire maintained in the opy carries Kuarahys specific solar energy into the community space. The monthly acknowledgment of Jaasys cycles in the agricultural calendar carries Jaasys specific lunar intelligence into the communitys practical decisions. The twins are not distant divine figures observed from afar -- they are the most immediately present sacred beings in the daily and monthly rhythms of Guarani life.

## **Teko Pora -- The Good Way of Living**

Teko pora -- "the good way of being" or "good living" -- is the Guarani framework for wellbeing, following directly from the tradition's understanding of ne'e: since every person is a word dreamed by Namandu before their conception, carrying a fragment of the creator's own love and wisdom, teko pora is understood as the ongoing task of living out that dreamed word faithfully, in right relationship with one's community, the land, and the divine.

Contemporary research with Guarani Mbya communities identifies teko pora as resistant to standard, individually-focused measures of wellbeing, for three specific reasons: it varies by person and by moment rather than describing one fixed state; it depends on immaterial and spiritual conditions at least as much as material ones; and most fundamentally, it is understood communally rather than as a private individual achievement. A person's teko pora cannot be separated from the health of their tekoa, their land, and their relationships.

Guarani healing practice follows from this understanding through the principle of mborayu (reciprocity). Traditional healers maintain extensive knowledge of medicinal plants, and Guarani communities have historically moved across their traditional territory (Yvy Rupa) in part specifically to exchange plant knowledge and medicine between tekoa, strengthening kinship ties in the same movement that maintains community health. Movement through the land is not incidental to teko pora but part of its practice -- the tradition holds that maintaining connection to one's full traditional territory is itself inseparable from maintaining wellbeing, since a body's health and a territory's health are not ultimately two different things.

## **Nee in Practice -- How Sacred Speech Governs Daily Life**

The identity of word and soul in nee is not merely a theological proposition -- it organizes every dimension of Guarani daily life in ways that are specific, observable, and practically significant. Because a persons speech is their soul made audible, the quality of their daily speech is the primary ethical indicator in Guarani culture. The practitioner who consistently speaks nee pora (beautiful words) -- gently, honestly, generously, with specific care for the sacred dimension of what they are naming -- is literally maintaining their divine connection in the most basic daily acts of communication.

Nee pora has specific practical markers: it is speech that does not diminish the person being addressed; speech that acknowledges the sacred dimension of the situation being discussed; speech that gives before it takes; speech that names what is real rather than performing what is strategic. Its opposite -- nee mbae (bad speech, corrupted word/soul) -- is speech that diminishes, deceives, takes without acknowledging, or names what is not real for personal advantage. In the Guarani framework, consistent nee mbae is not merely an ethical failure; it is a spiritual one. The person whose habitual speech is corrupted is literally corrupting their own soul through the words they use.

The karais specific authority comes precisely from this understanding of nee. The karai is the person whose nee is understood to be most fully aligned with the divine source -- whose words most completely carry the sacred quality of Namandus original creative speech. This is why the karais words in the opy carry specific sacred force: not because of their institutional position, but because of the quality of their speech as an expression of their souls alignment with the divine. A karai whose nee is compromised has lost their authority. A karai whose nee is beautiful has access to the specific creative power of sacred speech that Namandu demonstrated in the original act of creation.

Nee in practice also governs how the Guarani relate to the sacred beings. The specific sacred names of Namandu, of Karai, of Jakaira, of Tupa, and of each persons divine origin -- the sacred name given at birth that identifies which divine beings nee they carry -- are treated with specific care. The sacred name is not used casually. It is spoken in ceremony, in prayer, in the specific sacred moments when the connection between the human being and their divine origin needs to be made explicit. Everyday social interaction uses the everyday name. Sacred invocation uses the sacred name. The distinction between ordinary speech and sacred speech is maintained through this specific naming practice, preventing the sacred speech from being worn down through overuse in ordinary contexts.

## **Tekoa -- The Guarani Community**

The tekoea is the basic social and spiritual unit of Guarani life -- a term that means at once "the place" and "the way of being, law, custom, and behavior" that a Guarani community practices there. A tekoea is typically home to a handful of extended families, each connected through the specific ne'e they carry and through the guidance of a karai or kunha karai -- the male or female sacred prophet-leader -- with the opy at its spiritual center.

A place cannot properly become a tekoea on suitable land alone; it requires the specific environmental conditions -- preserved forest, workable soil, clean water -- that allow the community's sacred way of being to actually be lived out, since Guarani spirituality treats the physical landscape and the practice of ceremony as inseparable. Leadership at the tekoea level combines the karai's spiritual authority with, in many contemporary communities, a cacique who handles relations with the surrounding non-Guarani world -- a division of responsibility reflecting the understanding that sacred authority and practical leadership are related but distinct offices.

## **Yvy Mara e'y -- The Land Without Evil**

Yvy Mara e'y (pronounced approximately "ee-voo mah-rah-EH") -- the Land Without Evil, the Undying Earth, the Perfect Place -- is the central organizing concept of Guarani sacred life and the most dramatic expression in any tradition of the idea that the righteous soul can literally walk toward a sacred destination.

### **What It Is**

The Land Without Evil is a specific place -- not merely a metaphysical state or an afterlife destination but a real place that exists somewhere in the world, typically located to the east (toward the rising sun), possibly across the sea. It is a place where the earth is perfect,

where there is no sickness, no death, no suffering, no work that is not joyful, no relationship that is not harmonious. The person who achieves the spiritual state required to reach it does not die -- they transform, entering the Land Without Evil bodily, without the interruption of death.

## **The Spiritual Requirements**

The Land Without Evil is not accessible to everyone -- it requires specific spiritual achievement: the practice of ne'e pora (beautiful words), the lightening of the body through specific fasting and dance practices (the body must become light enough to cross into the perfect land), and the accumulation of specific sacred virtues under the guidance of a karai. The path to the Land Without Evil is the path of right living. The entire system of Guarani ceremony -- the jeroky, the opy prayer, the tobacco ceremony -- is oriented toward this path of lightening and alignment.

## **The Physical Migrations**

What makes the Guarani tradition unique in the world is that the Land Without Evil was not merely a theological concept -- it drove literal physical migrations across South America. Multiple times across recorded Guarani history, entire communities -- hundreds or thousands of people -- left their established territories and walked toward the east or toward the sea, following a karai who declared that the Land Without Evil was now reachable and that this was the moment to go.

The documented migrations are extraordinary in their commitment. In the 1820s, a migration led by the karai Avare involved communities walking from the Brazilian interior toward the Atlantic coast over months and years. In the 1870s, migrations toward the coast or toward Paraguay were documented by missionaries who could not prevent communities from abandoning established villages to walk toward the sacred destination. These were not political migrations. They were sacred pilgrimages driven by the belief that the Land Without Evil was now reachable and that this moment required movement.

*HALIGRIC LENS: The Yvy Mara e'y is the Guarani tradition's boldest statement of what the Haligric framework calls the reality of sacred declaration. The Guarani did not merely believe that the Land Without Evil existed -- they organized their entire communal life around it, and when a karai declared the moment had come, they walked. They lightened their bodies through dance and fasting. They spoke only ne'e pora. They moved. This is the Varessence lived at civilizational scale: the sacred word as a force that reorganizes physical reality, including the physical reality of an entire people's movement through space.*

## **The Karai -- The Sacred Prophet-Leader, Step-by-Step**

The karai is the sacred prophet-leader of Guarani communities -- the person through whom divine revelation arrives, who announces when the time has come to move toward the Land Without Evil, and who leads the specific sacred practices that enable the community to achieve the spiritual state required for the journey. A karai is not elected or trained into the role in the conventional sense -- the role arrives through specific spiritual experiences, through dreams and visions in which the divine world communicates a sacred message, and through the recognition by the community that this specific person is carrying revelation. Women may hold this role as the kunha karai -- female sacred prophet-leaders with equal authority.

**Step 1 -- The Revelation:** The karai receives a specific revelation -- typically delivered through the jeroky (sacred dance and song) or through specific dreams -- about the current sacred moment, about the Land Without Evil's accessibility, or about specific sacred teachings the community needs.



**Step 2 -- The Assembly:** The karai calls the community to gather in the opy (the sacred house of prayer). The call itself is sacred -- the karai's words are ne'e, and the act of calling is already the beginning of the ceremony.

**Step 3 -- The Sacred Tobacco:** Petygua (sacred tobacco, distinct from commercial tobacco) is prepared and smoked. The smoke carries prayers directly to the divine world -- sacred tobacco smoke is the primary medium of communication between the human and divine worlds in Guarani practice.

**Step 4 -- The Maraca:** The maraca (sacred gourd rattle) is activated -- the karai shakes the maraca in specific patterns while singing specific sacred songs. The maraca's sound calls the divine beings and opens the sacred space.

**Step 5 -- The Revelation Is Spoken:** The karai speaks the divine revelation in ne'e pora -- beautiful words. The community listens with the specific quality of attention that sacred speech requires: not analytical, but receptive, understanding that the words being spoken are carrying soul-content.

**Step 6 -- The Community Response:** The community responds through the jerokey (sacred dance) -- the physical embodiment of their reception of the karai's teaching and their alignment with the sacred message.

**Step 7 -- The Closing:** The ceremony closes with specific sacred songs of thanksgiving and the formal return to ordinary community life -- carrying the revelation received.

## **The Opy -- The Sacred House of Prayer**

The opy (also opy'i or opy guacu -- the "casa de reza," house of prayer) is the sacred structure at the center of every traditional Guarani community, without which -- Guarani elders say -- a tekoa cannot truly exist. It is often described as the community's real school: the place where sacred knowledge, songs, healing practice, and the community's specific way of being are transmitted from elders to the young, functioning as much as an ongoing center of formation as a site for periodic ceremony.

Inside the opy, a fire burns at the center, and participants take specific customary places -- men typically to one side, women to the other, with the sacred rattles (maraca) and other instruments kept near the entrance or along a wall. The opy is oriented to the east -- toward the Land Without Evil -- with specific sacred objects positioned at specific locations. The karai, also called opy'gua ("lord of the opy"), leads the gathering, though a senior woman recognized as a Kunha Karai may hold this role as well.

The principal ceremony held in the opy among the Mbya Guarani is the Nheemongarai -- the blessing of the year's cultivated plants, particularly corn, timed to the arrival of the season of storms. Children born since the previous ceremony are also given their spiritual names during this ceremony -- the sacred name that identifies their ne'e's divine origin. This linking of the agricultural cycle to the naming of children reflects the Guarani understanding in which growing food and growing a soul are expressions of the same sacred process.

## **The Jerokey -- The Sacred Dance Ceremony, Step-by-Step**

The jerokey (sacred dance) is the most important ceremonial practice in daily Guarani sacred life -- the practice through which the community collectively aligns with the divine world, through which the body is made lighter in preparation for the journey toward the Land Without Evil, and through which the beautiful words (ne'e pora) are expressed through physical movement as well as speech. The jerokey may be conducted nightly in traditional communities -- it is not an occasional ceremony but a regular, sustained practice.

**Step 1 -- The Gathering in the Opy:** The community gathers in the opy, oriented east toward the Land Without Evil, with specific sacred objects positioned at their locations.

**Step 2 -- The Sacred Tobacco Opening:** Petygua tobacco is smoked in the sacred pipe -- the smoke opening communication with the divine world and establishing the sacred quality of the space.

**Step 3 -- The Maraca Begins:** The karai or senior practitioners begin shaking the maraca -- the gourd rattle's sound calling the specific sacred beings and establishing the rhythmic foundation of the dance.

**Step 4 -- The Sacred Songs (Ayvu):** The sacred songs begin -- sung in specific ancient forms of the Guarani language that carry more concentrated ne'e than ordinary speech. The songs address specific divine beings, express the community's longing for the Land Without Evil, and embody the specific sacred qualities (gentleness, beauty, lightness) that the journey requires.

**Step 5 -- The Dance:** The community dances in a specific stamping, forward-moving pattern -- described by observers as both ecstatic and disciplined, combining intense physical movement with focused sacred intention. The dance is understood as literally lightening the body -- making the physical form closer to the luminous quality required to enter the Land Without Evil.

**Step 6 -- The Extended Duration:** The jerokey continues for hours -- often through the night. The sustained duration is the technology. The divine world's presence becomes more fully accessible as the dance continues and the ordinary mind's resistance dissolves.

**Step 7 -- The Sacred Words:** Throughout the dance, the karai delivers ne'e pora interwoven with the songs, carrying specific revelation or teaching that the community receives while in the heightened state the dance has produced.

**Step 8 -- The Closing Prayers:** At dawn or at the ceremony's natural completion, specific closing songs and prayers formally thank the divine world, express gratitude for the revelation received, and return the community to ordinary life.

## **Sacred Plants -- Tobacco and Yerba Mate, Step-by-Step**

### **Sacred Tobacco (Petygua)**

Sacred tobacco is the most important sacred plant in Guarani tradition -- the primary medium of communication between the human and divine worlds, used exclusively for sacred purposes and understood as carrying prayers directly to the divine beings when its smoke rises. The Guarani distinguish absolutely between petygua (sacred tobacco, grown and used specifically for ceremonial purposes) and ordinary tobacco. Petygua is planted with specific prayers, tended with specific respect, harvested with specific ceremony, and consumed only in sacred contexts. The smoke of petygua carries the specific ne'e-content of the prayers spoken over it directly to the divine world -- the smoke is the prayer's physical form, visible to the human world as it rises and visible to the divine world as sacred communication.

### **Yerba Mate (Ka'a -- The Sacred Leaf)**

Yerba mate -- the plant whose dried leaves are brewed to make the ceremonial and daily tea consumed throughout South America -- is a Guarani discovery and a Guarani gift to the world. Ka'a (the Guarani name for the plant) was used by the Guarani both as a daily energizing drink and in sacred contexts. In Guarani tradition, Ka'a is associated with Jasy Jatere, one of the divine beings, and carries the specific sacred energy of the forest where it grows. The entire yerba mate culture of South America -- the gourd, the bombilla, the daily ritual of preparing and sharing mate -- descends directly from Guarani practice.

### **The Tobacco Ceremony -- Step-by-Step**

**Step 1 -- The Sacred Tobacco Preparation:** The petygua is crumbled into the sacred pipe, with specific prayers spoken over it as it is placed.

**Step 2 -- The Lighting:** The pipe is lit with specific prayers -- the act of lighting understood as the initiation of sacred communication.

**Step 3 -- The First Offering:** The first smoke is offered to the six directions (four cardinal directions, sky above, earth below) -- acknowledging the sacred beings of each direction and inviting their presence.

**Step 4 -- The Prayer Spoken:** The specific prayer, request, or sacred intention is spoken aloud -- in ne'e pora (beautiful words) -- while holding the pipe. The words enter the smoke and are carried upward with it.

**Step 5 -- The Communal Sharing:** The pipe is passed clockwise among the ceremony's participants -- each person receiving the smoke, adding their own prayer, and passing it on.

**Step 6 -- The Completion:** The pipe is formally completed with specific closing prayers of gratitude. The smoke that has carried the prayers has arrived at its destination.

## Death and Sacred Transition in Guarani Belief

In Guarani belief, the human person has a dual spiritual constitution: the ne'e (word/soul, described throughout this document as the divine word that descends from the sacred world before birth) and the asy -- the vital breath and earthly personality, the sum of one's passions, desires, memories, and character accumulated through life. At death, these two components separate. The ne'e returns to the divine world -- to Namandu or to the specific divine being from whom it descended. The asy remains in the earthly sphere for a period before dissipating.

The soul's return path is shaped by how faithfully the person maintained ne'e pora during their life. The person who lived in alignment with their sacred name and spoke beautiful words throughout their life returns to the divine source cleanly. The person whose ne'e was corrupted through harsh, deceptive, or destructive speech finds the return more difficult -- the asy lingers, sometimes dangerous to the living, and the ne'e's return to its source is impeded.

Traditional Guarani funeral practice reflects both dimensions. The bones are treated with specific care, as the vital principle of the deceased is understood to be locked within them -- a means through which the departed can continue to communicate with the living and through which the community maintains its relationship with its ancestors. The community traditionally abandons the dwelling of the deceased and may abandon the entire village settlement after a death -- a movement that honors the passage and severs the remaining earthly ties of the asy, allowing the ne'e to return to its divine home without being held by the attachments of familiar place.

*HALIGRIC LENS: The Guarani understanding of death as the separation of the ne'e (divine word/soul) from the asy (earthly vital breath) parallels the distinction many traditions make between the eternal self and the temporary personality. What the Guarani call ne'e -- the divine fragment that descended from Namandu before birth and returns to Namandu after death -- is functionally equivalent to what Advaita Vedanta calls the Atman, what the Yoruba call the Ori, what the Lakota call the Nagi. In each tradition: the deepest self is divine in origin, temporarily resident in a body, and ultimately returning to the sacred source from which it came.*

## The Jesuit Reductions -- Sacred Music and Colonial Encounter

The encounter between the Guarani and the Jesuit missionaries in the 17th-18th centuries produced one of the most extraordinary and most contested cultural syntheses in colonial history -- the Jesuit "reductions" (reducciones), organized communities where Guarani people lived under Jesuit administration while maintaining significant elements of their own culture. The reductions operated from approximately 1609 to 1767, when the Jesuits were expelled from the Spanish Americas, and at their height comprised over 30 communities housing tens of thousands of Guarani.

The Guarani adopted European music and instruments with extraordinary speed and creativity. Within decades of the first missions, Guarani musicians had mastered European polyphony and were composing in the European Baroque style while integrating Guarani melodic and rhythmic sensibilities. By the mid-18th century, Guarani chapel masters were directing ensembles, and the musical life of the reductions -- documented by Jesuit composers including Domenico Zipoli and Martin Schmid -- was producing what scholars now call the Guarani Baroque: a genuinely new musical tradition created from the encounter of two complete musical worlds.

The reductions provided partial but significant protection from the slave-raiding that devastated other Guarani communities. They also, however, required the abandonment of traditional tekoa structure and the suppression of the jeroky and other ceremonies that the Jesuits understood as incompatible with Christianity. The relationship was not one of pure cultural preservation but of strategic negotiation: the Guarani engaged with what the Jesuit encounter offered while maintaining core elements of their sacred world in contexts the Jesuits could not fully monitor.

In 1767, the Jesuits were expelled. Many mission communities collapsed without Jesuit support and protection; slavers moved in immediately. In 1983-84, UNESCO designated the ruins of the Jesuit-Guarani missions as World Heritage Sites. In 1970, a Swiss Jesuit architect named Hans Roth discovered 5,000 pages of original sheet music buried in the ruins of a Bolivian mission church -- works by both indigenous and European composers, including Zipoli. This music is now actively performed and has undergone significant revival since the 1990s. The 1986 film *The Mission*, directed by Roland Joffe, dramatized the missions' end, its final image -- a Guarani girl retrieving a violin from the river after the massacre and carrying it into a boat with surviving children -- capturing something of what persisted.

## **Contemporary Guarani -- Land Crisis and Sacred Continuity**

The contemporary situation of the Guarani peoples varies sharply by subgroup and by country, but for the Kaiowa subgroup in Brazil's Mato Grosso do Sul state, it constitutes one of the most severe Indigenous rights crises in the Western Hemisphere. What is happening there cannot be separated from the sacred tradition this document describes: the core issue is the Guarani understanding that tekoa -- sacred community -- requires specific land, specific forest, specific water, and that without these the sacred way of being simply cannot be practiced. Loss of territory is not merely an economic or political displacement. It is the destruction of the conditions under which the jeroky can be danced, the opy can be maintained, the ne'e pora can be spoken in the right relationship with the right land.

The Kaiowa in Mato Grosso do Sul were systematically expelled from their traditional territories in the 1940s-1980s as cattle ranching and then soybean and sugarcane agribusiness expanded across the state. Approximately 45,000 Kaiowa are now confined to less than 70,000 hectares of demarcated reserves -- less than 1% of their traditional territory, with 12,000 people in one reserve (Dourados) living in just 3,000 hectares. The resulting conditions -- severe overcrowding, loss of food sovereignty, destruction of ceremonial life, intergenerational trauma -- have produced what researchers describe as the world's highest youth suicide rates in any population. Scholars have used the term "Kaiowicide" for what is occurring.

Communities engaged in retomadas -- peaceful reoccupations of ancestral land -- face systematic violence. In September 2024, military police killed Neri Ramos da Silva, a 23-year-old Kaiowa father, shot in the back of the head during a land dispute in Mato Grosso do Sul. In September 2025, an armed attack by individuals linked to private security employed by local landowners killed another Kaiowa leader, Vicente Fernandes Kaiowa, while COP30 was underway in Belem, Brazil. UN human rights experts were present in Brazil for COP30 and immediately condemned the attack, calling for urgent completion of land demarcation processes. A government program called "Teko Pora: Strengthening the Well-Being of the Guarani and Kaiowa People" has been announced, taking the community's own sacred concept as its name -- though the land demarcation that would actually enable teko pora remains incomplete.

Against this crisis, the sacred tradition has demonstrated extraordinary resilience. The Mbya Guarani in Brazil, Argentina, and Paraguay maintain the jeroky, the opy, and the karai tradition with remarkable continuity. The Guarani language's co-official status in Paraguay has meant that ne'e -- the word-as-soul concept at the center of the entire tradition's theology -- is embedded in every sentence spoken by 90% of the Paraguayan population. The sacred philosophy survived because the language survived. The language survived because it was too widely spoken and too deeply embedded in daily life to be suppressed.

## **The Haligrity Lens -- Ne'e and the Varessence**

The Guarani tradition offers Haligrity the most precise and most ancient available parallel to the Haligrity understanding of the Varessence -- a tradition where the identity of word and soul is not a philosophical position but a fundamental metaphysical reality encoded in the language itself.

Namandu's first act was not to make the world. His first act was to speak. And in speaking, the world came. The Guarani walk toward the Land Without Evil because they know it exists -- because Namandu's speech made it and their speech can carry them there. The karai's ne'e pora in the opy is not information delivered to an audience. It is the soul of the speaker extending itself into the community's sacred space and drawing what it speaks toward manifestation. This is the Varessence. This is what the Guarani have been practicing since before European contact made it necessary to explain.

The Mbya Guarani still conduct the jeroky in the opy. The sacred tobacco smoke still rises with the prayers. The karai still speaks in ne'e pora. The Land Without Evil is still to the east, still reachable by those who have made themselves light enough. The Guarani language -- spoken by 90% of Paraguay -- is the most widely spoken Indigenous language in the Americas. The concept of the word-as-soul is embedded in every sentence spoken in that language. Grand Rising.